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IT Project Management Support

Lecture 11

Managing Project Communications

- Project communication management
- Running Effective Meetings
- E-mail as an effective communication tool



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Project communications management

Based on:

[https://mosaicprojects.com.au/whitepaper/Conflict Management.pdf](https://mosaicprojects.com.au/whitepaper/Conflict%20Management.pdf)

<https://proventuresindia.com/blog/conflict-management-and-its-resources-engagement/>

<https://www.leadinganswers.com/2020/07/5-tools-for-team-conflict-resolution.html>

The goal of **Project Communications Management** is to ensure timely and appropriate generation, collection, dissemination, storage, and disposition of project information. There are three main processes in project communications management:

1. **Planning communications management** involves determining the information and communications needs of the stakeholders. Who needs what information? When will they need it? How will the information be given to them? The outputs of this process include a communications management plan and project documents updates.
2. **Managing communications** involves creating, distributing, storing, retrieving, and disposing of project communications based on the communications management plan. The main outputs of this process are project communications, project documents updates, project management plan updates, and organizational process assets updates.
3. **Controlling communications** involves monitoring and controlling project communications to ensure that stakeholder communication needs are met.

Importance of project communications management

- Many experts agree that the greatest threat to the success of any project, especially IT projects, is a failure to communicate.
- Many problems in other knowledge areas, such as an unclear scope or unrealistic schedules, indicate problems with communication.
- It is crucial for project managers and their teams to make good communication a priority, especially with top management and other key stakeholders.

Importance of training communications skills

- Many educational systems for IT graduates promote strong technical skills over strong communication and social skills.
- Most IT-related degree programs have many technical requirements, but few require courses in communications (speaking, writing, listening), psychology, sociology, and the humanities.
- People often assume that learning these soft skills is easy, but they are important skills, so people must learn and develop them.
- Many studies have shown that IT professionals need these soft skills just as much or even more than other skills.
- You cannot totally separate technical skills and soft skills when working on IT projects.
- For projects to succeed, every project team member needs both types of skills, and needs to develop them continuously through formal education and on-the-job training.

Importance of training communications skills

- In some situations you cannot have face-to-face meetings and must e-mail a large group of people.
- Many IT professionals work on virtual projects in which they never meet their project sponsors, other team members, or other project stakeholders.
- In a virtual project environment, it is crucial for project managers to develop clear communication procedures.
- They must use e-mail, web conferencing, instant messaging, discussion threads, project websites, and other technologies to communicate most information.
- They might be able to use phone calls or other media occasionally, but in general, they must rely on good written communications.

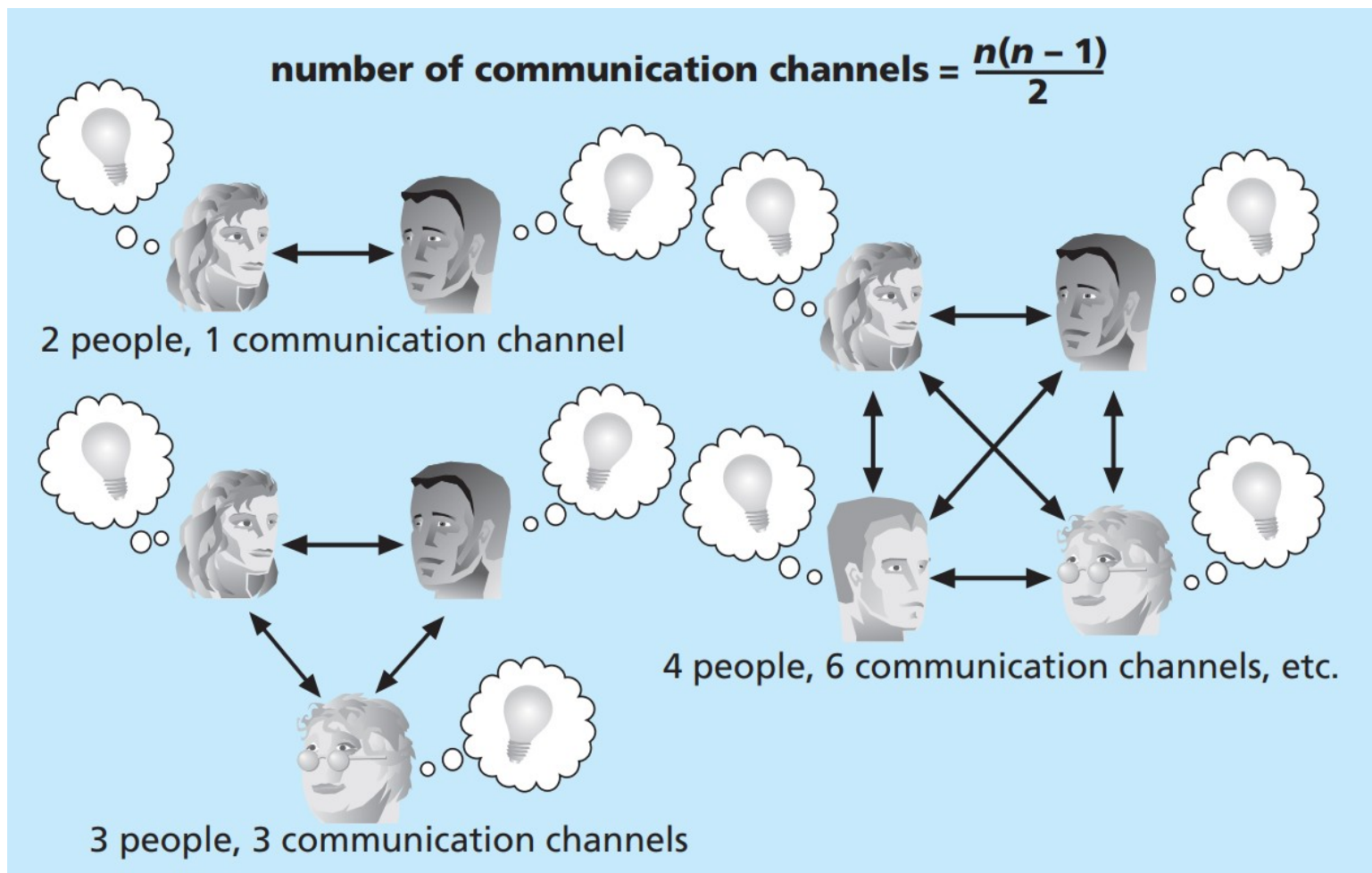
Determining the Number of Communication Channels

- A very important aspect of communications is the number of people involved in a project.
- As the number increases, the complexity of communication increases because there are more channels or pathways through which people can communicate.
- You can use the following simple formula to determine the number of communication channels as the number of people involved in a project increases:

$$\text{number of communication channels} = \frac{n(n - 1)}{2}$$

- where n is the number of people involved.
- For example, two people have one communication channel: $(2(2 - 1))/2 = 1$.
- Three people have three channels: $(3(3 - 1))/2 = 3$.
- Four people have six channels, five people have 10, and so on.

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The impact of the number of people on communication channels

Determining the Number of Communication Channels

- You can see that as the number of people increases above three, the number of communication channels increases rapidly.
- **Project managers should try to limit the size of teams or subteams to avoid making communications too complex.**
- For example, if three people are working together on a particular project task, they have 3 communication channels.
- If you added two more people to their team, you would have 10 communication channels, an increase of 7.
- If you added three more people instead of two, you would have 15 communication channels, an increase of 12.
- You can see how quickly communication becomes more complex as you increase team size.

Planning communications management

- Because communication is so important on projects, every project should include a communications management plan — a document that guides project communications.
- This plan should be part of the overall project management plan.
- The communications management plan varies with the needs of the project, but some type of written plan should always be prepared.
- For small projects, such as the project management intranet site project, the communications management plan can be part of the team contract.
- For large projects, it should be a separate document.

Planning communications management

- The communications management plan should address the following items:
 1. Stakeholder communications requirements
 2. Information to be communicated, including format, content, and level of detail
 3. Who will receive the information and who will produce it
 4. Suggested methods or technologies for conveying the information
 5. Frequency of communication
 6. Escalation procedures for resolving issues
 7. Revision procedures for updating the communications management plan
 8. A glossary of common terminology

Stakeholder communications analysis

- It is important to know what kinds of information will be distributed to particular stakeholders.
- By analyzing stakeholder communication needs, you can avoid wasting time or money on creating or disseminating unnecessary information.
- Table below provides part of a sample stakeholder communications analysis that shows which stakeholders should get particular written communications.

Stakeholders	Document Name	Document Format	Contact Person	Due
Customer management	Monthly status report	Hard copy and meeting	Tina Erndt, Tom Silva	First of month
Customer business staff	Monthly status report	Hard copy	Julie Grant, Sergey Cristobal	First of month
Customer technical staff	Monthly status report	E-mail	Li Chau, Nancy Michaels	First of month
Internal management	Monthly status report	Hard copy and meeting	Bob Thomson	First of month
Internal business and technical staff	Monthly status report	Intranet	Angie Liu	First of month
Training subcontractor	Training plan	Hard copy	Jonathan Kraus	November 1
Software subcontractor	Software implementation plan	E-mail	Najwa Gates	June 1

Selecting the Appropriate Communication Methods and Media

- There are three broad classifications for communication methods:
 1. **Interactive communication:** As the name implies, two or more people interact to exchange information via meetings, phone calls, or video conferencing. This method is usually the most effective way to ensure common understanding.
 2. **Push communication:** Information is sent or pushed to recipients without their request via reports, e-mails, faxes, voice mails, and other means. This method ensures that the information is distributed, but does not ensure that it was received or understood.
 3. **Pull communication:** Information is sent to recipients at their request via websites, bulletin boards, e-learning, knowledge repositories like blogs and wikis, and other means.



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Running Effective Meetings

Running Effective Meetings (1)

- A well-run meeting can be a vehicle for fostering team building and reinforcing expectations, roles, relationships, and commitment to the project.
- However, a poorly run meeting can have a detrimental effect on a project.
- For example, a terrible kick-off meeting may cause important stakeholders to decide not to support the project further.
- Many people complain about the time they waste in unnecessary or poorly planned and poorly executed meetings.
- The following guidelines can help improve time spent at meetings:

Running Effective Meetings (2)

1. Determine if a meeting can be avoided.

- Do not have a meeting if there is a better way to achieve the objective at hand.
- For example, a project manager might need approval from a top manager to hire another person for the project team.
- It could take a week or longer to schedule even a 10-minute meeting on the top manager's calendar.
- Instead, an e-mail or phone call describing the situation and justifying the request is a faster, more effective approach than having a meeting.
- However, you often do need a face-to-face meeting in certain situations because using e-mail or a phone call would be inappropriate.
- Consider which medium would be most effective.

Running Effective Meetings (3)

2. Define the purpose and intended outcome of the meeting.

- Be specific about what should happen as a result of the meeting.
- Is the purpose to brainstorm ideas, provide status information, or solve a problem?
- Make the purpose of a meeting very clear to all meeting planners and participants.
- For example, if a project manager calls a meeting of all project team members without knowing the true purpose of the meeting, everyone will focus on their own agendas and very little will be accomplished.
- All meetings should have a purpose and intended outcome.

Running Effective Meetings (4)

3. Determine who should attend the meeting.

- Do certain stakeholders have to be at a meeting to make it effective?
- Should only the project team leaders attend a meeting, or should the entire project team be involved?
- Many meetings are most effective with the minimum number of participants possible, especially if decisions must be made.
- Other meetings require many attendees.
- It is important to determine who should attend a meeting based on its purpose and intended outcome.

Running Effective Meetings (5)

4. Provide an agenda to participants before the meeting.

- Meetings are most effective when the participants come prepared.
- Did they read reports before the meeting?
- Did they collect necessary information?
- Some professionals refuse to attend meetings if they do not have an agenda ahead of time.
- Insisting on an agenda forces meeting organizers to plan the meeting and gives potential participants the chance to decide whether they need to attend.

Running Effective Meetings (6)

5. Prepare handouts and visual aids, and make logistical arrangements ahead of time.

- By creating handouts and visual aids, you must organize thoughts and ideas.
- This usually helps the entire meeting run more effectively.
- It is also important to make logistical arrangements by booking an appropriate room, having necessary equipment available, and providing refreshments or entire meals, if appropriate.
- It takes time to plan for effective meetings.
- Project managers and their team members must take time to prepare for meetings, especially important ones with key stakeholders.

Running Effective Meetings (7)

6. Run the meeting professionally.

- Introduce people, restate the purpose of the meeting, and state any ground rules that attendees should follow.
- Have someone facilitate the meeting to make sure that important items are discussed, watch the time, encourage participation, summarize key issues, and clarify decisions and action items.
- Designate someone to take minutes and then send them to all participants soon after the meeting.
- Minutes should be short and focus on the crucial decisions and action items from the meeting.

Running Effective Meetings (8)

7. Set the ground rules for the meeting.

- State up front how the meeting will be run.
- For example, can people speak at will, or will the facilitator lead discussions?
- Can attendees use their laptops or other electronic devices during the meeting?
- Don't assume that all meetings are run in the same way.
- Do what works best in each specific case.

Running Effective Meetings (9)

8. Build relationships.

- Depending on the culture of the organization and project, it may help to build relationships by making meetings fun experiences.
- For example, it may be appropriate to use humor, refreshments, or prizes for good ideas to keep meeting participants actively involved.
- If used effectively, meetings are a good way to build relationships.



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E-mail as an effective communication tool

How to use e-mail as an effective communication tool (1)

- Be sure to send e-mail to the right people. Do not automatically “reply to all” on an e-mail, for example, if it is not necessary.
- **Use meaningful subject lines in e-mails** so readers can quickly see what information the message contains. If the entire message can fit in the subject line, put it there. For example, if a meeting is cancelled, just enter that message in the subject line. Also, do not continue replying to an e-mail thread when the subject has changed without changing the subject line. The subject line should always relate to the latest topic.
- **Limit the content of the e-mail to one main subject.** Send a second or third e-mail if it relates to a different subject.
- **The body of the e-mail should be as clear and concise as possible.** Use as few words as possible while maintaining a clear and friendly tone. If three questions need to be answered, number them as questions 1, 2, and 3 and put each on a separate line.
- **Always reread your e-mail before you send it.** Also, be sure to check your spelling using the spell-check function.

How to use e-mail as an effective communication tool (2)

- **Limit the number and size of e-mail attachments.** If you can include a link to an online version of a document instead of attaching a file, do so.
- Delete e-mail that you do not need to save or that does not require a response.
- Do not even open e-mail that you know is not important, such as spam. Use the e-mail blocking feature of the software, if available, to block unwanted junk mail.
- Make sure that your virus protection software is up to date. Never open e-mail attachments if you do not trust the source.
- **Respond to e-mail quickly, if possible.** It will take you longer to open and read the e-mail again later. In addition, if you send an e-mail that does not require a response, make that clear as well.
- If you need to keep e-mail, file each message appropriately. Create folders with meaningful names to file the e-mail messages you want to keep. File them as soon as possible.



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Thank You very much
for your attention